

SONRISE FINALLY

Upholding a time-honoured family tradition, Rahul takes the plunge in party organisation. With a young team by his side, he is set to script future of the Congress.

■ By Priya Sahgal

They call him Sonia's Dhoni. The day Rahul Gandhi took over as Congress general secretary, the Indian cricket team lifted the Twenty20 World Cup. Even his most astute strategist couldn't have scripted a better omen for the young scion. The very next day Rahul attended his first official meeting at the Congress headquarters. His first proposal: the Congress should felicitate the Team India at Nehru Stadium.

The only question surrounding Rahul's induction into the party organisation was about the timing. It was a given that the 37-year-old would follow the time-honoured tradition of his family and take his first political steps handling the party's youth wings. Rajiv was 39 when he was made general secretary and a year later prime minister. Sanjay Gandhi was Youth Congress chief at 28 while Indira Gandhi became a member of the Congress Working Committee (cwc) at 38. Congressmen had begun clamouring for Rahul to take office at 24 Akbar Road ever since Ambika Soni was drafted into the Government from the organisation in January 2006. Eight months later, A.K. Antony and Oscar Fernandes followed the same route. Yet the party chief made no move to fill the vacancies waiting for a reluctant Rahul to finally say yes. That he agreed at a time when the country is poised to go in for a mid-term poll is significant. His team is clearly going to be the highlight of the political showcase that the Congress will take to the polls.

The packaging is a tried and tested one. Although he has been made gen-

ALL IN THE FAMILY: Rahul with Sonia and brother-in-law Robert

